



The Power of POSSIBILITY

HOW A SHARED SENSE OF IDENTITY AND
AN EXTREME FORM OF DEMOCRACY
KEEP ALIVE A COUNTRY WHERE THE
NATIONAL PROJECT IS NOT A BAD IDEA

BY PATRICK FRENCH

Some years ago, I began to collect Indian wall charts, inspired by one called 'Top Officials of the World'. It was a little out of date, and showed Margaret Thatcher wearing a bizarre glam-rock jacket, and Ronald Reagan covered in at least a week's worth of stubble, thanks to the haphazard printing process. My favourite chart was 'An Ideal Boy', which showed wonderfully evocative, stylised cartoons of an exemplary son of India. The ideal boy is a chubby-thighed little fellow who gets up early, bathes daily, reads attentively at school and goes for a morning walk in a well-manicured garden, wearing shorts. He "brushes up the teeth", salutes his parents and "takes meals in time", his mother hovering shyly over his shoulder and popping a roti on to his plate. The ideal boy is paler than most people in India, and

has a definitely Hindu look to him, but I doubt the chart was intended to be sectarian. Matching him on the 'Bad Habits' wall chart are some less-than-ideal boys who fly kites in a dangerous fashion, gamble (though with well-combed hair) and "take law in hands" by throwing a cricket ball through a shop window. On another chart, illustrating the law of *karma*, a naughty boy jettisons a banana skin and promptly slips over on it.

The sentiment, the naïve optimism and the moral ambition of 'An Ideal Boy' arise directly from the nationalist project that began in 1947. Like Doordarshan, the wall charts have a strong sense of mission and suggest a worldview that is

now starting to fade. India's didactic intention was a product not only of Independence and the political activities that led to it, but of the raw wound of Partition. When territory was re-worked into a neighbouring state and the original aim of the freedom movement was exposed and subverted by the successful quest for a Muslim homeland, it became necessary to find a secular basis for the new India, in which religion would not be permitted to define identity. Although he never made the point explicitly, I believe that Nehru's own attitude was conditioned by the violence he witnessed in 1947-48 as he toured riot-torn towns and